

CLOSED NETWORK

PRIVACY PODCAST

The Flock Briefing Packet

A resident's toolkit for asking hard questions about license-plate surveillance in your town.

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SOURCE

github.com/ClosedNetwork/closed-network-resources

Closed Network — the privacy podcast for people who'd like to keep some.

What this packet is

This is a leave-behind. A talking-points doc. A “where do I even start” guide for people who just learned their town runs a network of always-on cameras that read every license plate that drives by — and who’d like to do something about it.

You don’t need to be an activist. You don’t need to be a privacy expert. You need about an hour, the address of your city council, and the willingness to be the person at the meeting who actually asks the question.

This packet is built for one specific situation: **a Flock Safety camera network is operating, or being proposed, in your community, and you want to push back.** Everything in here is sourced. Everything is current as of April 2026. Use it.

The 90-second version

Flock Safety is a private company that sells AI-powered cameras to police departments, HOAs, and businesses. The cameras read every license plate that drives past, log it to a national searchable database, and increasingly identify cars by color, dents, bumper stickers, and roof racks even without reading the plate (a feature Flock calls “vehicle fingerprinting” in its NOVA product line).

Once your town joins, your local data gets fed into a national network that other agencies — including federal ones — can search.

Here is what we know happened in 2025:

- **A Texas sheriff’s office searched 83,000 cameras nationwide looking for a woman who self-administered an abortion**, with the search log entry reading “had an abortion, search for female.” Court records later showed it was opened as a “death investigation” into the fetus.
- **404 Media revealed local police across the country were running searches on behalf of ICE**, often labeled “ICE” or “illegal immigration” right in the search field.
- **The San Francisco Police Department let outside agencies make over 1.6 million unauthorized searches** of its Flock data, including at least 19 tied to ICE.
- **At least eight Washington state agencies** had set up direct one-to-one Flock sharing with U.S. Border Patrol.
- **An EFF analysis of 10 months of search logs** found more than 50 federal, state, and local agencies ran hundreds of Flock searches tied to protest activity, targeting known activist groups.
- **Flock cameras were installed in Cambridge, Massachusetts after the city ordered them removed.** Cambridge terminated the contract over what it called a “material breach of trust.”

Two members of Congress have opened a formal investigation. At least 30 cities and towns have either deactivated their cameras or canceled their contracts since the start of 2025. You can be the one to put your town on that list.

What Flock actually is (plain English)

Flock Safety builds three things you should know about:

1. ALPR cameras (Automated License Plate Readers). The little black-and-white cameras you’ve probably driven past without noticing — usually mounted on a small solar-powered pole at an intersection or neighborhood entrance. Each one photographs every passing vehicle, reads the plate via OCR, and uploads it to Flock’s cloud, where it’s stored for at least 30 days by default and indexed in a searchable national network.

2. Vehicle fingerprinting (NOVA and “Vehicle Fingerprint” features). Flock’s newer products go beyond plates. They identify a vehicle by color, make, body style, dents, bumper stickers, roof racks, and decals — meaning they can flag and follow your specific car even if your plate is dirty, obscured, or temporarily covered. This is the feature that makes “I’ll just put a plate cover on” a non-answer.

3. The Flock network. This is the part most residents don’t know about. When your town’s police department signs up for Flock, by default their data is queryable by other agencies that also use Flock. That includes police, sheriffs, state patrols, and — until recently, and in many cases still — federal agencies. Your local cameras are part of a national surveillance grid. The default settings have repeatedly turned out to share more than residents were told.

The receipts

A short, sourced timeline of what’s actually been documented. Bring this to your city council meeting.

May 2025 — 404 Media uncovers ICE pipelines

404 Media reports that local police nationwide had been performing Flock searches on behalf of ICE. The searches were only discovered because officers had typed words like “ICE” or “illegal immigration” directly into the required search-reason field.

May 2025 — A Texas sheriff searches the country for an abortion

The Johnson County, Texas Sheriff’s Office runs a search across more than 83,000 Flock cameras nationwide, with the stated reason: *“had an abortion, search for female.”* Court records obtained later by EFF show the office opened a “death investigation” into the fetus and consulted the District Attorney about charging the woman.

August 2025 — Congressional investigation opens

Reps. Raja Krishnamoorthi and Robert Garcia open a formal congressional investigation into Flock, demanding records of every search tied to ICE, CBP, and abortion.

August / September 2025 — Sedona, AZ becomes the first Arizona city to terminate

After a 5-1 vote to pause the program, the Sedona City Council unanimously votes to fully terminate its Flock contract and remove every camera in city limits.

September 2025 — SFPD scandal

The San Francisco Police Department is revealed to have allowed outside police agencies to make over 1.6 million unauthorized searches of its Flock database, including searches tied to ICE.

October 2025 — Washington state's open door

A University of Washington Center for Human Rights report documents that at least eight Washington law enforcement agencies — Benton County Sheriff and police in Arlington, Auburn, Lakewood, Richland, Sunnyside, Wenatchee, and Yakima — had enabled direct one-to-one Flock sharing with U.S. Border Patrol.

October–December 2025 — Cambridge, MA terminates over “breach of trust”

Cambridge orders Flock cameras turned off. Then, in late November, Flock installs two new cameras in the city *after* being told to stop. In December, Cambridge formally terminates the contract, citing “material breach of trust.”

November 2025 — EFF: Flock used to surveil protesters

The Electronic Frontier Foundation analyzes 10 months of nationwide Flock search logs and finds that more than 50 federal, state, and local agencies ran hundreds of searches tied to protest activity, including searches targeting known activist groups.

December 16, 2025 — Flagstaff votes unanimously to remove all 32 cameras

The Flagstaff, Arizona City Council votes unanimously to end its Flock contract and immediately deactivate all 32 automated license plate cameras installed around the city.

December 2025 — Eugene and Springfield, Oregon end their programs.

January 2026 — Santa Cruz, California ends its contract.

Ongoing — Redmond, WA shuts down ALPRs

After learning Border Patrol had improperly accessed neighboring Auburn’s Flock system, Redmond’s City Council votes unanimously to turn off its own ALPR cameras.

Ongoing — Cameras dismantled

Reporting from Bloodinthemachine.com and others documents a parallel, decentralized phenomenon: residents across the U.S. cutting down, spray-painting, and physically destroying Flock cameras. *Closed Network does not endorse this*. We do, however, note that Flock’s CEO has publicly called the legal mapping project DeFlock.me a “terroristic organization” — which tells you something about how the company treats criticism.

“But I have nothing to hide”

You don’t have to. The point of this technology isn’t to catch you doing something wrong — it’s to make sure that anyone with access to the database can reconstruct where you’ve been, who you’ve visited, and what your patterns look like, going back as long as the data is retained.

A short list of things this has already been used for, all documented:

- **Tracking a woman who had an abortion across state lines.**
- **Searching for activists and protesters.**
- **Performing searches on behalf of immigration enforcement** that the local agency had no authority to assist with.
- **Stalking ex-partners** (multiple documented cases of officers misusing Flock for personal reasons).
- **Searches using slurs against the Romani community** — EFF documented over 80 agencies doing this in audit logs.

The question isn’t whether *you* have something to hide. The question is whether you trust every police officer in every jurisdiction in the country, plus every federal agency that talks them into a “favor search,” with a real-time map of your movements. Forever.

If you ever want to attend a protest, visit a clinic, see a lawyer, go to a union meeting, attend a place of worship, or visit a partner your family doesn’t know about — your privacy depends on this network not existing or being radically constrained.

What to do this week

Three lanes. Pick one. Pick all three.

Lane 1: Find out what your town has (15 minutes)

1. Go to **deflock.me** and search your city. The map shows known Flock and other ALPR camera locations, crowdsourced and verified.
2. Cross-reference with **atlasofsurveillance.org** (a project of the EFF and University of Nevada, Reno) to confirm whether your local PD is listed as a Flock customer.
3. Search your local news for “[Your city] Flock” or “[Your city] license plate readers.” Note any council meetings where it was discussed and how they voted.

That’s your starting brief. Now you know what’s installed and who voted for it.

Lane 2: File a public records request (30 minutes)

You have a legal right to ask. Templates are below, and there’s a multi-state toolkit at **github.com/rpriven/flock-public-records-toolkit** with state-specific citations for 20+ states. Use the FOIA template at the back of this packet to request:

- The full contract, MOUs, and data-sharing agreements between your city and Flock.
- The full audit log of who has searched your local cameras (including external agencies), with timestamps and stated search reasons.
- Any communications between your local PD and Flock about federal data sharing, ICE, CBP, or out-of-state agencies.

Important: Flock auto-deletes camera data after 30 days. **Mark your request as expedited.**

Lane 3: Show up to the meeting (2 hours)

This is the one that actually moves cities. Find when your city council or police oversight commission meets, sign up for public comment (usually a 2-3 minute slot), and use the script at the back of this packet. If you can bring three other people, you’ve already done more than 90% of residents anywhere ever do.

The single most effective sentence at a city council meeting is: **“I’d like to know specifically what this council has done to verify that our Flock data isn’t being shared with federal immigration enforcement, and I’d like that answer in writing before the next meeting.”** Then sit down.

A FOIA / Public Records Request you can copy and paste

TO: Records Custodian / Public Records Officer **AGENCY:** [Insert your police department or city name] **DATE:** [Insert today's date] **RE:** Public records request — Flock Safety surveillance program

Pursuant to [state public records law — e.g., the California Public Records Act, the Massachusetts Public Records Law, the Texas Public Information Act, the Freedom of Information Act], I am requesting the following records:

1. Any and all contracts, master service agreements, statements of work, memoranda of understanding (MOUs), data-sharing agreements, and renewal documents between [agency] and Flock Group, Inc. (d/b/a Flock Safety), in effect at any time from January 1, 2023 to the present.
2. Any policy, procedure, general order, or training material governing employee use of Flock Safety automated license plate reader (ALPR) systems, including the stated criteria for permissible search reasons.
3. The complete Organization Audit Log and Network Audit Log from Flock Safety's "Insights" tab, covering January 1, 2024 through the date of this request, including: timestamp of each search, the agency conducting the search, the user (or user ID) conducting the search, and the stated reason for each search.
4. Any internal or external communications (emails, memos, reports) between [agency] personnel and Flock Safety, U.S. Immigration and Customs Enforcement (ICE), U.S. Customs and Border Protection (CBP), or any out-of-state law enforcement agency, regarding access to or sharing of [agency]'s Flock data.
5. Any audit, review, or compliance assessment of [agency]'s Flock program conducted internally or by an outside party.

I am requesting metadata about system usage (search counts, agency names, timestamps, stated reasons) — I am not requesting the underlying ALPR images or plate data captured by the cameras.

I am requesting expedited processing because Flock Safety auto-deletes ALPR data on a 30-day rolling basis, which creates a continuing risk that responsive records will be destroyed during normal processing time.

Please provide records in electronic format (PDF or CSV) and waive fees in the public interest, as these records bear directly on the public's understanding of how surveillance technology funded by public dollars is being used.

If any portion of this request is denied, please cite the specific exemption and provide an estimate of the volume of records being withheld.

Thank you, [Your name] [Your contact info]

You can submit this by email to your city clerk, your police department's records division, or via your state's public records portal. **MuckRock.com** lets you file and track requests publicly, which adds useful pressure.

Your two-minute city council script

Read this if you have nothing else prepared. Customize the bracketed parts.

“Good evening. My name is [name] and I’m a resident of [city/ward].

I’m here about our Flock Safety camera program. In 2025, we learned that local police departments around the country were using Flock to run searches on behalf of ICE, to track at least one woman across state lines after she had an abortion, and to surveil protesters. The San Francisco police let outside agencies run 1.6 million unauthorized searches of their Flock data. Cambridge, Massachusetts terminated its Flock contract for what they called a material breach of trust. Sedona, Flagstaff, Eugene, Springfield, Santa Cruz, and Redmond have all pulled the plug. Congress has opened a formal investigation. I have three questions for the council and the chief, and I’d appreciate written answers before the next meeting.

One: Has our department audited every external agency that has searched our Flock data in the last 12 months, and can you confirm in writing that none of those searches were on behalf of federal immigration enforcement?

Two: What is our retention period, who has read access, and what is the process if a resident wants to know whether their plate has been searched?

Three: What specific, measurable benefit has this program produced that we could not have achieved without surrendering this data into a national network?

Until those questions are answered in public, I’d ask the council to suspend the program. Thank you.”

That’s it. Sit down. Let other people speak.

Common pushback, and how to answer

“It’s just license plates. Plates are public information.” *Bulk, persistent collection of public information becomes private surveillance. A single officer noticing your plate at a protest is policing. A national searchable database of every plate at every protest going back months is something different — and the courts are starting to catch up. A November 2025 Washington court ruled that data captured by Flock cameras is a public record subject to disclosure.*

“It catches criminals. Don’t you want to catch criminals?” *Flock’s own crime-reduction claims are largely self-reported and not independently verified. Independent reviews and the ACLU have found minimal hard evidence that ALPR networks meaningfully reduce crime. Meanwhile, the documented misuse — ICE searches, abortion tracking, protester surveillance, officers stalking ex-partners — is not theoretical.*

“Our PD would never let it be misused.” *That is exactly what Cambridge thought. And SFPD. And the Washington agencies whose data was shared with Border Patrol without their leadership’s knowledge. The technology is designed in a way that makes misuse easy and detection hard. “We trust our chief” is not a substitute for an audit.*

“You can opt out, right?” *No. There is no opt-out for being driven past a Flock camera. If you live in or commute through a Flock-covered area, your plate is in the database. The only meaningful opt-out is at the city level.*

“What about kidnapping cases? Stolen cars?” *Existing tools — AMBER alerts, NCIC, targeted warrants — handle these without standing up a national, persistent dragnet. The question isn’t whether ALPR can occasionally help; it’s whether the documented harms outweigh the marginal benefit. So far, 30+ cities have decided they don’t.*

Resource directory

Maps & data - DeFlock.me — crowdsourced map of Flock and ALPR camera locations, with iOS and Android apps for adding new ones. - **Atlas of Surveillance** (atlasofsurveillance.org) — EFF + Univ. of Nevada, Reno’s database of which agencies use which surveillance tech. - **AlprWatch.org** — analysis of FOIA’d Flock audit logs.

Organizing - Stop Flock (stopflock.com) — campaign hub with talking points and organizing resources. - **Fight for the Future / FlockOut** (fightforthefuture.org/actions/flockout) — toolkit for running a campaign in your city. - **EFF Street-Level Surveillance** (eff.org/issues/street-level-surveillance) — deep-bench legal and policy material. - **ACLU “Community Control Over Police Surveillance” (CCOPS)** — model ordinance language used in cities like Milwaukee.

Public records - MuckRock.com — file, track, and publish FOIA requests publicly. - **rpriven/flock-public-records-toolkit** (GitHub) — multi-state public records request templates with state-specific legal citations for 20+ states. - **Have I Been Flocked?** (footnote4a.org/news/flock-vs-foia) — guide to checking Flock audit logs for searches involving your plate.

Reporting to follow - 404 Media — original investigative reporting on the ICE and abortion search scandals. - **Electronic Frontier Foundation** (eff.org) — ongoing legal analysis and FOIA work. - **State of Surveillance** (stateofsurveillance.org) — running tally of city wins and losses. - **The Record from Recorded Future News** — Flock-related security and policy reporting. - **Closed Network** (the show you’re holding a packet from) — for the longer-form stuff.

A note from Closed Network

This packet exists because we keep getting asked: “Where do I even start?” So here it is. A starting line.

The most surprising thing we've learned doing this show is how *small* the gap is between someone reading about Flock for the first time and someone showing up at a city council meeting and changing the outcome. Sedona did it. Flagstaff did it. Cambridge did it. Cambridge had the cameras yanked because residents wouldn't shut up about it.

You don't need permission. You need an hour, this packet, and the willingness to be visible.

If you use this packet to do something — file a request, speak at a meeting, get a vote on the agenda — tell us. We'll cover it on the show. The privacy fight is a series of unglamorous local meetings, and the people who show up are the ones who win.

— *Simon and the Closed Network team*

Sources

Every claim in this packet traces back to a public source. The list below is what we used.

ICE & federal access - 404 Media — “Flock Removes States From National Lookup Tool After ICE and Abortion Searches Revealed” - Center for Human Rights, University of Washington — “Leaving the Door Wide Open: Flock Surveillance Systems Expose Washington Data to Immigration Enforcement” (Oct. 2025) - The San Francisco Standard — “SFPD let outside cops search city surveillance data for ICE” (Sept. 2025) - Courthouse News Service — “California drivers accuse Flock Safety of sharing data with federal and out-of-state agencies” - ACLU — “I’m Hearing About More Pushback Against Flock, Fueled by Concern Over Anti-Immigrant Uses”

Abortion search - 404 Media — original reporting on Texas search of 83,000 cameras - Range Media — “Texas deputy searched Spokane County Flock cameras for a woman who had an abortion” - EFF — “Flock Safety and Texas Sheriff Claimed License Plate Search Was for a Missing Person. It Was an Abortion Investigation.” - Business and Human Rights Centre — case writeup

Congressional investigation - 404 Media — “Congress Launches Investigation into Flock After 404 Media Reporting” - Letter from Reps. Krishnamoorthi and Garcia to Flock CEO Garrett Langley (Aug. 6, 2025) — krishnamoorthi.house.gov

City decisions - City of Cambridge, MA — official statement on Flock contract termination (Dec. 2025) - The Boston Globe / Boston.com — “Cambridge ends contract for license plate cameras after ‘breach of trust’” - The Harvard Crimson — “Cambridge Ends Contract With License Plate Reader Amid Concerns Over ‘Breach of Trust’” - Cambridge Day — “City cancels deal for license plate tech” - KJZZ / Sedona.biz / AZ Free News — Sedona timeline (Aug.–Sept. 2025) - Hoodline / FOX 10 Phoenix — Flagstaff Council vote Dec. 16, 2025 (32 cameras removed) - NPR — “Why some cities are canceling Flock license plate reader contracts” (Feb. 2026) - State of Surveillance — “23 Communities Told Surveillance Cameras to Get Out. Here’s How.” and “The Flock Rebellion: Cities Pull the Plug on License Plate Surveillance” - The Record from Recorded Future News — “Flock cameras remained active in two cities where officials had asked for them to be turned off”

Protester surveillance - EFF — “How Cops Are Using Flock Safety’s ALPR Network to Surveil Protesters and Activists” (Nov. 2025)

DeFlock and resistance - EFF — “Anti-Surveillance Mapmaker Refuses Flock Safety’s Cease and Desist Demand” (Feb. 2025) - 404 Media — “Flock Threatens Open Source Developer Mapping Its Surveillance Cameras” - The New Republic — “The Nationwide Revolt Against Flock Safety Cameras” - Blood in the Machine — “Across the US, people are dismantling and destroying Flock surveillance cameras” - The Nation — “These AI-Powered Surveillance Cameras Are Everywhere—and People Have Had Enough”

Public records / FOIA - GitHub: rpriven/flock-public-records-toolkit - MuckRock — example Flock FOIA filings (Decatur, Houston) - footnote4a.org — “Have I Been Flocked?” - AlprWatch.org — analysis of FOIA’d audit logs - EFF — “Washington Court Rules That Data Captured on Flock Safety Cameras Are Public Records” (Nov. 2025)

ACLU policy work - ACLU — “Flock’s Aggressive Expansions Go Far Beyond Simple Driver Surveillance” - ACLU — “Flock Can Share Driver-Surveillance Data Even When Police Departments Opt Out, And Other Flock Developments” - ACLU of Washington — “It’s time to regulate Flock Cameras and ALPRs, with the Driver Privacy Act” - ACLU of Colorado — Durango proposed ordinance (regulation framework)

The Closed Network Privacy Podcast — for people who’d like to keep some. Hosted by Simon. New episodes weekly.

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